

# SERIES DOSSIER: THE PUNISHER: WELCOME BACK, FRANK

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Phase 5 · Disney+ Series #1 (Saga Two, Series #3)

Status:  DOSSIER COMPLETE (awaiting showrunner lock)

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## 1. IDENTITY

| Field                  | Entry                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Series #               | Phase 5, Series #1 (limit: 2 this phase)                                                                                  |
| Phase                  | Phase 5, <b>The Secret Wars Saga</b> : "Time Runs Out"                                                                    |
| Real title             | <i><b>THE PUNISHER: WELCOME BACK, FRANK</b></i> (the 616 storyline)                                                       |
| Decoy / codename title | " <i>NEIGHBORHOOD WATCH</i> "                                                                                             |
| Premiere               | Tuesday, March 3, 2026                                                                                                    |
| Finale                 | Tuesday, May 5, 2026                                                                                                      |
| Episodes               | 10 (one a week, Tuesdays)                                                                                                 |
| Episode runtime        | 50–58 minutes                                                                                                             |
| Platform               | Disney+ (real history: in 2025 Disney+ moved its Marvel premieres to Tuesday nights, starting with Daredevil: Born Again) |
| Showrunner             | Steve Lightfoot                                                                                                           |
| Rating                 | TV-MA, under the R-rated street-level label                                                                               |
| Genre + second genre   | Superhero crime drama + <b>pitch-black comedy</b> / <b>urban war story</b>                                                |

## Episode schedule

| Ep | Title                 | Airdate             |
|----|-----------------------|---------------------|
| 1  | "Welcome Back, Frank" | Tue, March 3, 2026  |
| 2  | "Ma"                  | Tue, March 10, 2026 |
| 3  | "Hell's Kitchen"      | Tue, March 17, 2026 |
| 4  | "The Vigilantes"      | Tue, March 24, 2026 |
| 5  | "Spacker Dave"        | Tue, March 31, 2026 |
| 6  | "The Russian"         | Tue, April 7, 2026  |
| 7  | "Joan"                | Tue, April 14, 2026 |
| 8  | "Soap"                | Tue, April 21, 2026 |
| 9  | "Zoo"                 | Tue, April 28, 2026 |
| 10 | "Goodbye, Ma"         | Tue, May 5, 2026    |

## 2. OWNERSHIP

| Field                             | Entry                                                                                                                    |  |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| Whose series / franchise is this? | JON BERNTHAL, who has played the Punisher since <i>Captain America: Civil War</i> (2016). The Punisher franchise is his. |  |

| Character                                                              | Actor                                                 | Age at premiere |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Frank Castle / The Punisher                                            | Jon Bernthal                                          | 49              |
| Ma Gnucci                                                              | Fresh casting ( <i>never played by a real actor</i> ) | —               |
| The Russian                                                            | Fresh casting                                         | —               |
| Det. Martin Soap                                                       | Fresh casting                                         | —               |
| Joan the Mouse / Spacker Dave / Mr. Bumpo ( <i>Frank's neighbors</i> ) | Fresh casting                                         | —               |
| Matt Murdock / Daredevil ( <i>Episodes 3–4</i> )                       | Charlie Cox                                           | 43              |
| Wilson Fisk ( <i>Episode 10 post-credit</i> )                          | Vincent D'Onofrio                                     | 66              |

### 3. SOURCE MATERIAL (EARTH-616)

| Field                    | Entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Primary comic(s) adapted | " <i>Welcome Back, Frank</i> ", <i>The Punisher</i> vol. 5 #1–12 (2000–01), Garth Ennis & Steve Dillon: <b>Frank Castle comes back to New York and goes to war with the Gnucci crime family. Ma Gnucci hunts him, copycat vigilantes appear, the Russian gets sent to kill him, and Detective Soap is assigned to catch him.</b> |
| Supporting comics        | <i>Amazing Spider-Man</i> #129 (1974, the Punisher's first appearance) · <i>Punisher: Year One</i> (1994, his family's murder) · <i>Welcome Back, Frank</i> #3 (2000, <b>Daredevil</b> tries to stop Frank)                                                                                                                      |
| Nerf check               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> <b>Frank is the most dangerous man in New York.</b> No powers, just <b>Marine training and will.</b> <b>The Russian beats him in round one</b> , as on 616, and Frank wins the rematch.                                                                                                      |

#### 3A. COMIC ACCURACY REPORT

| Field                  | Entry                                                                                     |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Overall accuracy score | <b>97%.</b> Ennis and Dillon's run is adapted issue for issue, including its black humor. |

##### Straight from the page:

- **Frank Castle**, a Marine whose **family was murdered in Central Park**, comes back to **wage war on the Gnucci family** (#1).
- **Ma Gnucci** loses her sons, then **her limbs** (Frank feeds her to polar bears at the zoo, and she survives), and **keeps coming** (#1–12).
- **Copycat vigilantes** (a priest, a retired cop, and a stockbroker) try to "be the Punisher" (#4–5).
- **The Russian**, a giant hired killer, **nearly beats Frank** (#6).
- **Detective Martin Soap**, the NYPD's most useless cop, is **put on the Punisher case** (#1–12).
- **Frank's neighbors**, Joan the Mouse, Spacker Dave and Mr. Bumpo, **end up helping him** (#1–12).
- **Daredevil** tries to stop him. **Frank drugs him** (#3).
- **Frank burns down the Gnucci mansion with Ma inside** (#12).

**How the violence is handled:** TV-MA, **true to Ennis's tone**, including his dark comedy. **The violence is never glamorized.** Frank is a **tragic figure**, not a role model.

##### POWERS & ABILITIES

| Character           | 616 powers & abilities                                                                             | Shown in the series                    | Held back (why) | Match     |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------|
| <b>The Punisher</b> | <b>Peak human; Marine special-forces training;</b> master of every weapon, tactician, interrogator | Dismantles a crime family in ten weeks | –               | ✓<br>100% |
| <b>The Russian</b>  | <b>Superhuman durability and strength</b> (nearly)                                                 | Wins round one                         | –               | ✓<br>100% |
| <b>Daredevil</b>    | As in <i>Born Again</i>                                                                            | The rooftop fight in Hell's Kitchen    | –               | ✓<br>100% |

## 4. STORY

| Field                       | Entry                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Logline</b>              | Frank Castle comes home to New York to kill every member of a crime family, and finds himself with a copycat problem, a useless cop on his tail, and neighbors who won't leave him alone. |
| <b>Theme</b>                | <b>War never ends.</b> Frank's only family now is the one he can't get rid of: the lonely people in his building.                                                                         |
| <b>Villain / antagonist</b> | <b>Ma Gnucci</b> (main); <b>the Russian</b>                                                                                                                                               |

### What the season is about

- **Episodes 1–3:** Frank's back. The Gnuccis lose three sons in one night. **Ma Gnucci** swears revenge. **Detective Soap** gets the case. **Daredevil** tries to stop him on a rooftop, and Frank drugs him: "*Go home, Red.*"
- **Episodes 4–6:** **Copycat vigilantes** show up. Frank shuts them down. Ma Gnucci loses her limbs **at the zoo**. **The Russian** comes for Frank, and **Frank loses**.
- **Episodes 7–9:** Frank recovers **in his neighbor Joan's apartment**. He has something like a home now. The rematch with the Russian ends with Frank winning.
- **Episode 10:** **The Gnucci mansion burns** with Ma inside. Frank leaves the city at dawn. Joan leaves a light on for him.

## 5. MCU TIMELINE PLACEMENT

| Field                   | Entry                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| When it's set           | Monday, June 2, 2025 → Saturday, September 27, 2025.                                                                      |
| Where it's set          | New York City (Hell's Kitchen, Little Italy, <b>the Central Park Zoo</b> )                                                |
| Relative to other films | It runs at the same time as <i>The Kree-Skrull War</i> . Frank ignores the alien war in the sky: <i>"Not my problem."</i> |

## 6. WORLD-BUILDING

### The series' own world

- **The R-rated street level:** Frank and Matt, **Soap**, Frank's neighbors.

### World-building for the wider MCU

| Seed          | How it appears    | Payoff                |
|---------------|-------------------|-----------------------|
| Fisk's return | Post-credit scene | Street level, Phase 6 |

### Setting up the Big Bad (THE SECRET WARS SAGA)

| Seed                                  | How it appears                                                                    | What it means                                     |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| The end of the world, from the street | Frank, looking at two Earths in the sky: <i>"World's ending. Still got work."</i> | The Incursions are <b>visible to everyone</b> now |

## 7. POST-CREDIT SCENE (Episode 10)

| Field                 | Entry                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Post-credit scene     | ✅ <b>"MAYOR."</b> Wilson Fisk, in a sharp suit, stands at a podium on the City Hall steps: <i>"...and as your next mayor, I promise to restore order to this city."</i> |
| Secret shoot codename | <b>"CAMPAIGN SEASON."</b>                                                                                                                                               |

## CHECKLIST

- ☒ Comic(s) adapted · ☒ Comic Accuracy Report + powers · ☒ Real and decoy titles · ☒ What it's about · ☒ Villain · ☒ Post-credit scene · ☒ The series' own world-building · ☒ MCU world-building · ☒ Big Bad setup · ☒ Whose franchise · ☒ When and where in the timeline · ☒ **Episode count, runtimes and release pattern**